Nehru’s next announcement was to have far-reaching consequences: ‘We have in fact placed this border area of NEFA directly under the military authorities. That is to say it was being dealt with by the Assam Rifles Directorate, which was functioning under the Governor of Assam, and the governor is the agent of the Government of India, in the External Affairs Ministry. …The Assam Rifles will of course remain there and such other forces as will be necessary will be sent, but they will function now under the army authorities and their headquarters.’

## WHOSE LINE WAS IT ANYWAY?

This impromptu reorganizing of India’s defence structure was done to reassure Parliament that the prime minister was on the job, and the announcement was met by the thumping of tables by Congress MPs who probably had no idea of the real implications of the announcement. Not only had Nehru ignored Thimayya’s views on the availability of troops, he also discounted the dominant view in military circles that believed the Indian Army could only fight the PLA after drawing it to the plains—it is highly unlikely that Nehru had even informally consulted the army chief before making this statement.

Just as the Panchsheel Agreement had forced the government to hide the truth from the people of India, Nehru’s unconsidered remark on 28 August 1959 had major national and international implications. The prime minister spoke to Parliament about the Chinese threat and the defence of India’s borders for the first time, and also in the same breath declared that the army would be committed for the job. By committing Army HQ, which had no troops of its own in NEFA into the existing defence structure of manning border posts, the prime minister was committing it to a policing role. Any plans for the defence of the region that could be based on a forward line held by the police (Assam Rifles) and an inner line held by the army evaporated.

In his office in South Block, General Thimayya was oblivious of the drama that was being played out in the Lok Sabha less than a kilometre away. Until that moment, the army was not particularly involved with the day-to-day situation with China in either Ladakh or NEFA. Reports in the newspaper that morning had resulted in curious army officers trying to pinpoint Longju in the Subansiri region on the NEFA map. As far as they